

11th-hour bid to curb Russian rockets

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POLITICO's must-read briefing on what's driving the day in Brussels, by Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur and Gabriel Gavin. By GABRIEL GAVIN GOOD MOR

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GOOD MORNING — I'm Gabriel Gavin, coming to you after France lost 2-0 to Spain in the World Cup semifinals, dampening spirits at last night's Bastille Day celebrations in Brussels. More on that later ...

In today's Playbook:

- Talks on the EU's Russia sanctions collapsed; a meeting this morning might save them.
- Crunch time for a string of major legal cases.
- Faces in the crowd: Roxana Mînzatu, Vsevolod Chentsov, Philippe Musquar, Ylva Johansson, Pedro Sánchez, Danilo Della Valle, Gennady Timchenko, Shehbaz Sharif and many more.

On today's Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Ian discuss the high-stakes push to plug Ukraine deeper into the EU's defense machine.

DRIVING THE DAY

SANCTIONS SHOWDOWN: EU ambassadors are expecting a tense battle this morning over how to put the squeeze on Russian oil and gas revenues — money Moscow uses to pay for the rockets it fires at Ukraine. And it's all happening while European leaders launch an effort to get Kyiv the air defenses it needs to shoot down whatever Russia sends its way.

Coming back to it: Envoys have been forced to reconvene today after late-night talks on Tuesday failed to produce an agreement on the bloc's new sanctions package — the 21st since the start of the full-scale war.

No war profit: The proposals call for a price cap on Russian oil to be frozen at \$44.10 per barrel. Without it, the renewed conflict in the Middle East could push up energy prices, letting Moscow charge more and generating extra revenue for its war effort. The new sanctions would also target the banks and other financial intermediaries that pay for these fossil fuels.

Closing window of opportunity: Without an agreement today, the Commission will be obliged to revise up the price cap in the coming weeks.

Tough talk: Greece is concerned about how the restrictions will affect the shipping industry, said two diplomats, granted anonymity to speak frankly. Austria, meanwhile, has revived a campaign to get compensation for Raiffeisen Bank, which opted to stay in Russia and would lose out from new measures restricting money flows. Neither country responded immediately to a request for comment.

"It's very hard," said one senior EU diplomat preparing for today's negotiations. "But we are still hoping for a result." Others were more vocal: "Many countries have companies that lost money as a result of leaving Russia," said a second diplomat. "It's ridiculous that a company would get compensation after having stayed there for four years and earned money."

All in the timing: European countries will today announce a bid to get Ukraine the advanced weaponry it needs to shoot down Russian missiles, in a major move to cut Kyiv's dependence on American support.

Funding commitment: Commission President Ursula von der Leyen will lead a delegation to Ukraine where the leaders of Greece, Romania, Croatia, Slovenia and others are expected to sign a new "Kyiv Declaration" that commits to mobilize funding and logistics to secure air defenses. POLITICO has seen a draft of the joint statement.

Integration, not handouts: "We are talking to the EU at the institutional level [about] how to boost our cooperation in [the] defense industry field," Ukrainian Ambassador to the EU Vsevolod Chentsov told my colleague Zoya Sheftalovich. "The issue is not only how the EU can financially support Ukraine's defense industry, but also how Ukraine's defense industry can be integrated into the broader European defense industrial base."

Meanwhile, Putin's next move could be a Baltic incursion, Russian opposition activist Garry Kasparov has warned. Such a move could target countries on NATO's eastern flank, such as Latvia or Estonia, he said.

BIG AND BREAKING

TOLL FREE: U.S. President Donald Trump appears to have backtracked on his earlier threat to charge a 20 percent fee on cargo transiting the Strait of Hormuz, while Reuters is reporting that the U.S. has resumed its blockade of Iranian ports. And as the war restarts, there's little sign that diplomacy can stop it.

NEW DELHI, NEW DEAL: The EU and India will today kick off formal talks to allow the world's most populous country to take part in the Horizons Europe research and development scheme, Morning Tech tells Pro readers. Top EU diplomat Kaja Kallas and trade chief Maroš Šefčovič also meet their Indian counterparts today.

BIG GAME: Italian Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni's plans to ease restrictions on hunting have become a new battleground in Italy's culture wars ahead of an election next year.

SPANISH FAMILY FIGHT: Plans by conservatives in Madrid's regional government to offer family benefits linked to unborn children have triggered a new clash over abortion rights and warnings of "Trumpian politics."

EXCLUSIVE — NEW PARTY SHERIFF: European Parliament legal adviser and Sciences Po trade-policy lecturer Philippe Musquar will become the next director of the Authority of European Political Parties, starting on Sept. 1. Musquar will be in charge of policing party financing and issuing sanctions, succeeding Pascal Schonard.

SUMMER LEGAL SPRINT

CASES TO WATCH: The final (real) working week before summer means EU courts are set to move on some big, outstanding cases. Here are our top picks of the ones to follow ...

Catalan separatism: On Thursday, the European Court of Justice will rule on Spanish Prime Minister Pedro Sánchez's amnesty of Catalans behind the 2017 independence referendum. Judges will decide whether the vote undermined the EU's financial interests or amounted to terrorism — two offenses excluded from amnesties under Spanish law.

Parliamentary transparency: A Czech watchdog is suing the European Parliament after it failed to hand over MEPs' individual travel expenses, citing personal privacy concerns. A win for the website Kverulant.org could mean greater access to lawmaker expenses in future. A General Court decision is slated for today .

Russian sanctions: A slew of cases today and tomorrow will see the European Council's decision to sanction Russian and Belarussian individuals come under the scrutiny of the EU's top tier Court of Justice. Perhaps the most significant case involves billionaire oil trader Gennady Timchenko. He was sanctioned for, among other things, having participated in a meeting at which Vladimir Putin discussed the impact of a possible war in Ukraine, days before Russia's Feb. 24, 2022, invasion. Some argue the evidence used to justify some sanctions is worthy of review .

Last tech standing: The European Court of Justice will hold a hearing this morning in the last of the Big Tech cases to wind through EU courts — and the only one the Commission has actually lost. As Jacob Parry writes in the Fair Play newsletter , the EU executive is trying to revive its €1.49 billion Google decision on AdSense for Search — the service that used to place Google search ads on third-party websites. The Commission's penalty was annulled in full by the General Court in September 2024.

Fun fact: A ruling in this case isn't expected before 2027 — more than a decade after Google dropped the disputed clauses.

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

The EU's Rule of Law Report for 2026 is coming up this week. But what is it? It's an annual report that evaluates the state of the rule of law across all EU member countries and some enlargement countries, and features sections on the justice system, anti-corruption, media pluralism and freedom, and other institutional issues relating to checks and balances. The idea is to flag problems before they escalate.

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RETRAINING WORKERS

SKILLS BEFORE SPILLS: Brussels' answer to Europe's industrial upheaval: Invest in retraining workers. Commission Executive Vice President Roxana Mînzatu will today unveil who gets to participate in the EU's Skills Guarantee Pilot projects.

Das Auto: Under the pilot, the Commission will distribute €14 million among six projects spanning 10 EU countries, focused on car-industry workers whose jobs are at risk, a Commission official familiar with the plans but not authorized to speak on the record told Playbook's Zoya Sheftalovich.

PREEMPTIVE RESKILLING: The idea is to move people into new roles through targeted reskilling and upskilling before they lose their jobs, rather than helping them afterward. The projects will run until 2028, with their results feeding into a Skills Guarantee under the EU's future Competitiveness Fund.

The backdrop to the announcement is grim. Volkswagen Group said it's considering cutting up to 100,000 jobs worldwide — double the number previously signaled. Europe's biggest carmaker, which owns VW, Porsche, Audi, Seat and Skoda, is under pressure from falling sales in China, U.S. tariffs and intensifying competition from lower-cost Chinese rivals.

Also happening today: Ylva Johansson, who chairs the European Skills High-Level Board that brings together business, universities, training providers and social partners, will hand Mînzatu the board's first draft recommendations. Those proposals are intended to shape the Commission's next wave of skills initiatives and help workers navigate Europe's green and digital transitions

MFF FINISH LINE

IRELAND'S MFF CHARM OFFENSIVE: Ireland will use a September gathering of Europe ministers in Dublin to finalize a budget compromise ahead of a meeting of EU leaders, Gregorio Sorigi tells us. Ireland's Europe minister Thomas Byrne signaled his intention to fast-track negotiations over the bloc's €2 trillion budget in a presentation to colleagues on Tuesday.

Summer work: Byrne said he will hold bilateral meetings in September with fellow Europe ministers to identify a landing zone for the seven-year budget, which is due to take effect in 2028. Dublin, in its role as president of the Council of the EU, is expected to present a new set of figures and a revised package of EU-wide taxes before a leaders' summit in October. "I urge you and your teams to make use of months ahead to assess pragmatically and collegially where you can compromise," Byrne said.

5 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

STEEL YOURSELF: Facing tariffs from the U.S. and competition from China, the EU is putting an iron ring around its steel market. But other countries that want to export to the bloc are feeling the pain .

MONEY FOR THE MAGA-ALIGNED: The U.S. state department is offering grants of up to \$3 million for European groups that combat "censorship" and develop "civilizational bonds" with the U.S., the FT reports .

SÁNCHEZ VS. JUDICIARY: The brother of Spanish Prime Minister Pedro Sánchez was convicted on Tuesday of having been unfairly handed a public sector job by officials. The controversial trial of David Sánchez was the latest in a string of legal woes facing the Spanish government.

ARE YOU FILMING ME? The European Commission has relaxed rules that effectively limited the sale of “smart glasses” following pressure from the U.S. and big tech lobbying.

ENLARGEMENT PERIL: Southern Italy stands to lose big from EU enlargement, according to a study commissioned by The Left group. An EU-36 could see Sardinia lose up to 58 percent of its EU funding, Campania 32 percent and Sicily 29 percent. “Regions across Spain, Portugal, Greece, Romania and beyond risk a social massacre too, without adequate compensation,” MEP Danilo Della Valle told Playbook.

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Sunny, high of 29C.

FIRE CLAIMS SIX LIVES: A fire that broke out at the OXY building on De Brouckère Square Tuesday has left six workers dead. The cause of the blaze remains unknown, Le Soir reports . Minister-President of Brussels-Capital Region Boris Dilliès said he was “deeply saddened” by the deaths of those working on the building’s renovation.

READ ALL ABOUT IT: British bookseller Waterstones will open a second shop in Brussels, the company told Brussels Playbook. The two-floor outlet will open in October on Avenue Louise.

ROUDABOUT REVOLUTION: Brussels residents have launched a new petition urging authorities to install the grassy canopy originally planned by architects for the Robert Schuman Roundabout, which is now just a giant concrete eyesore in the heart of the EU quarter. More than 1,000 people have already signed .

A-PEELING PRESENT: EU leaders and politicians have been inundated by ripe, juicy mangoes, delivered as gifts by the boxful, with the compliments of Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif. Pakistan is seeking closer economic relations with Europe and in April held a major joint forum designed to boost business ties.

Hungarian Prime Minister Péter Magyar, is the latest to confirm he received a whopping total of 90 Pakistani mangoes , with António Costa and Ursula von der Leyen also on the list. Playbook got its collective hands on a crate and can report that the mangoes very good, albeit messy to eat.

NO FÊTE ACCOMPLI: The elite of France’s diplomatic establishment in Brussels gathered Tuesday night for a Bastille Day celebrations in a swelteringly hot art gallery off Avenue Louise. But a screening of the French mens’ football team’s unexpected 2-0 loss to Spain was enough to chill the patriotic fervor.

SPOTTED ... enjoying mounds of slightly melted brie and copious glasses of champagne: French EU Ambassador Philippe L glise-Costa and PSC Ambassador Mathilde F lix-Paganon; EU High Representative for Foreign Affairs and Security Policy Kaja Kallas; Spanish Foreign Minister Jos  Manuel Albares; French spokespersons R my Tirouttouvarayane and Vincent Lieser; David Oppenheimer, deputy head of cabinet to the European Council president, and spokesperson Maria Tomasik; Alexandre Adam, deputy head of cabinet to the European Commission president; European Parliament Secretary-General Alessandro Chiocchetti; European Economic and Social Committee President S amus Boland and his Head of Cabinet  amonn Mac Aodha ...

And more ... European Commission spokespeople Anna-Kaisa Itkonen and Anouar El Anouni, along with social media chief Adalbert Jahnz; DG IDEA’s Antoine Bondaz; Belgian spokesperson Sofia Smorscek

(sans her Smurfs costume); U.K. Embassy's John O'Regan; German spokesperson Julian Fricke; Danish spokesperson Fabrice Jacobsen; Euractiv's Elisa Braun and Nicoletta Ionta; FT's Barbara Moens, Andy Bounds and Ian Johnson; Le Soir's Agathe Declaire; POLITICO's Zoya Sheftalovich, Marianne Gros, Camille Gijss, Gerardo Fortuna and Gabriel Gavin.

ALSO SPOTTED ... at the summer recital of the European Parliament's choir in the Yehudi Menuhin stage: Alessandro Chiocchetti; Patriots for Europe Secretary-General Philip Claeys; NEOS' Peter Berry and Akim van der Voort; MEPs Lukas Sieper, Udo Bullmann and Loránt Vincze; APAs Oleksandra Kobernik and Bernarda Scharf.

SPOTTED ... sipping Aperol Spritz, listening to a live saxophonist and eating fresh pizza and gelato at Generali's summer reception at the Italian ambassador's residence: Generali Chairperson Andrea Sironi; EU Parliament VP Martin Hojsík; MEPs Carlo Fidanza, Letizia Moratti, Irene Tinagli, Raffaele Stancanelli, Giorgio Gori, Alexander Jungbluth, Fernand Kartheiser, Giuseppe Lupo, Massimiliano Salini, Raffaele Topo, Francesco Torselli, Petr Bystron, Elisabeth Dieringer and Dora Dávid, along with adviser Stefano Felician Beccari.

And breathe ... EU Commission's Mario Nava, Marco La Marca, Andrea Beltramello and Valeria Miceli; European Central Bank's Boris Kisselevsky; Dutch Perm Rep's Vincent Rietvink; Italian Perm Rep's Michele Maltese; CEPS' Karel Lannoo; Generali's Simone Bemporad, Fabio Marchetti, Jean Plattard, Virginia Di Marco, Carolina De Giorgi and Tuulike Tuulas; Insurance Europe's Thea Utoft Høj Jensen; Zurich Insurance Company's Sabine Seggelke; GDV's Florian Wimber; ANIA's Gianfranco Dell'Alba; POLITICO's Francesca Micheletti and Kathryn Carlson.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: An unusual summer press conference presents Chancellor Friedrich Merz with an opportunity. But can he stay calm, cool and collected?

London: Outgoing PM Keir Starmer will face his final parliamentary questions as his slow march toward the end continues.

Paris: Tensions will remain high in the National Assembly today, as lawmakers cast their final vote on the end-of-life care bill, scheduled for late afternoon.

Washington PM: Federal Reserve Chairman Kevin Warsh was handed a life raft when the government reported a stark decrease in inflation last month.

AGENDA

— European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen visits Kyiv.

— Coreper II meets at 9 a.m.; Coreper I meets at 9:30 a.m.

— NATO Deputy Secretary-General Radmila Shekerinska will take part in a meeting of the Committee on Security and Defence (SEDE) the European Parliament.

— European Commission Executive Vice-President Henna Virkkunen joins the Third EU-India Trade and Technology Council.

— Trade Commissioner Maroš Šefčovič participates in the EU–India Trade and Technology Council and receives India’s Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal.

— International Partnerships Commissioner Joseph Síkela receives Indian Foreign Minister Subrahmanyam Jaishankar.

— European Council President António Costa meets with UNRWA Commissioner-General Christian Saunders.

— Startups Commissioner Ekaterina Zaharieva receives Jaishankar.

— Budget Commissioner Piotr Serafin meets with Minister-President of Brussels-Capital Region Boris Dillies.

— Environment Commissioner Jessika Roswall receives Argentina’s Secretary of State for International Economic Relations Fernando Brun.

BIRTHDAYS

Former MEP Hynek Blaško; the European Data Protection Board’s Greet Gysen; International Rescue Committee President David Miliband; Jimena Gomez de la Flor, from the European Flavour Association; Séverine de Lartigue, from the French embassy in Washington; Hassan al Bolkiah, sultan of Brunei; former Portuguese President Aníbal Cavaco Silva.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO’s EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Griera, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Ferdinand Knapp and Milena Wälde, editor James Panichi and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

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